

The CHIndness of Strangers: Exploring Reciprocity and Pro-Social Action

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CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → *HCI theory, concepts and models*;

Keywords

Care ethics; Feminist HCI; pro-social behaviour; reciprocity; Art CHI; Making, Research through Design

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1 Main goal of the meet-up

The primary goal of the meet-up is to establish a new CHI community with a particular interest in exploring digital means to facilitate non-digital reciprocity and pro-social action, building on previous work by the organisers that explores care ethics and the value of making for others. We will do this in two ways. First, we will facilitate and celebrate the exchange of hand-made gifts between strangers, which will allow us to explore a radically new form of building connections between CHI delegates, asking them to craft a small gift for an unknown other, based on a strictly limited understanding of their likes and dislikes. Second, these gifts, themselves, will be used as prompts for discussion around the role of making within the CHI community, the value of physical vs. digital gift-giving, and the social and psychological benefits of enacting reciprocity. Reciprocal making is not a *requirement* for participation: while a small number of participants will have pre-made gifts for each other, all other meet-up participants will be able to view

the made objects and observe the gift exchange, and then all participants together will be able to engage in the discussions.

2 Overview of activities

The gift-making will take place before or possibly during CHI (dependent upon the scheduling of the meet-up). Essentially, the organisers will set up a website which will invite CHI delegates to indicate their interest in the gift exchange portion of the meet-up ahead of time and then submit a response to a set of probes (prompting understanding of favourite activities, foods, colours and colour palettes, places and hobbies). These responses will be used to pair delegates, who will then be invited to make something for the unknown other and bring it to the meet-up, where they will be exhibited, and an exchange of gifts will take place. Making (guides, templates) will be made available digitally, and we will share pointers about the sourcing of raw materials (e.g., air-dried clay, fabric). Participants will also be encouraged to record aspects of the making activities, and some discussion at the meet-up will involve the way that the repository of photos, videos and other making artifacts can be used. The gifts will be exhibited during the meet-up to prime discussion around the value of reciprocity, considerations of anonymity at early stages of a gift-giving process and design considerations for the orchestration of such reciprocal activities.

3 Organisers

- Pam Briggs (Primary Contact) is a Professor in Applied Psychology at Northumbria University. Her HCI work explores issues of trust, identity, privacy and wellbeing, often with marginalised communities. She also has an ongoing ceramics practice.
- Jayne Wallace is a Professor of Craft and Wellbeing at Northumbria University, whose work explores the potential of design and digital technologies, jewellery and the act of making to support a sense of self across a range of human contexts.
- Rob Bowman is a senior technician and photographer at Northumbria University. His photography and videography practice supported the clay connections project.



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- Kyle Montague is a Professor of Participatory AI at Northumbria University. He seeks to address critical social problems and challenges by designing and configuring digital technologies that empower individuals and marginalised communities.
- Claire Craig is a Helen Hamlyn Co-Chair of Design and Professor of Inclusive Design in Ageing at the Royal College of Art. She utilises design methods, including object-elicitation, photography, and creative practice, to build an understanding of the experiences of vulnerable individuals.
- Austin Toombs is an Associate Professor of Informatics at Indiana University. His research explores the role of digital technologies on community formation, with an interest in how the formation and sanctioning of interpersonal relationships impacts the inclusivity, welcomeness, and diversity of a community.

4 Community of Interest

Description of the Community to which this meet-up would be of interest There are several CHI communities who would be interested in this proposal, and these include, firstly, the Arts in HCI community and those who seek to understand how art practice can function as a method of inquiry in HCI, as well as those who recognise that HCI researchers often engage in a plurality of practices that may include artistic expression [4]. Secondly, the Research through Design (RtD) community, who increasingly place emphasis on making as a mode of exploration [3]. Thirdly, the feminist HCI [1] community and those researchers with an interest in care ethics [5] would be interested in the underlying notions of gift-giving as a powerful community care process. However, as noted above, this provides an opportunity to establish a new community of interest around reciprocity and pro-social behaviour.

Why would this meet-up be of interest? The global Covid-19 pandemic prompted a new, transient interest in digitally facilitated acts of kindness between strangers [2], but for some CHI communities, this focus on kindness and care ethics has been a critical part of their work. For many other researchers, the desire to 'do good' remains a key, albeit quiet, goal, yet increasingly this work is taking place in a very difficult political climate. This meet-up offers an opportunity for a variety of communities to come together to share their interests in making and reciprocity to exchange gifts, share knowledge about the ways that reciprocity promotes social and psychological wellbeing, and to explore novel digital means to promote kindness.

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Supplementary Material

Primary Contact

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Assumed attendee background

Any attendee would be welcome, but we would particularly encourage those who have some affinity with the communities of interest described above, who are interested in reciprocity and/or the value of making. We would also encourage those who are attending CHI for the first time and/or those who do not have a pre-existing network of CHI 'friends' and who would simply like the opportunity to meet through this exchange and/or explore the resulting exhibition. Note that we would anticipate that the presence of hand-made artifacts within the meet-up would act as a prompt for casual exchanges between delegates from any background.

The approach you will use for organizing and presenting the meet-up

This meet-up uses an approach developed by the first three authors for their **Clay Connections** project which focused on reciprocal making between members of a pottery group for people living with brain changes, including dementia and members of a pottery group for those who experience mental health problems and/or social exclusion. Members of each group responded to design probes which were then exchanged with the unknown other and these acted as inspiration for the making of a dinner setting for their project partner (a dinner plate, side plate, bowl and drinking vessel). An exchange event took place at the end of the making period, followed by a public exhibition¹ of the work.

This meet-up will adapt this process to include (i) a microsite with access to probe materials, (ii) an online (and pseudo-anonymised) submission of interests and preferences in response to the probes, (iii) links to online making resources and suggestions for offline materials, (iv) an invitation to the meet-up, and (v) an exchange of gifts and exhibition of the made work followed by discussion of topics, outlined below. Those delegates who did not take part in the exchange process will be invited to explore the exhibition, meet the exhibitors and fully participate in the subsequent discussions.

¹<https://www.northumbria.ac.uk/about-us/news-events/events/2025/09/centring-and-clay-connections-exhibition/>

An informal schedule of discussion topics

- Making, reciprocity and wellbeing
- Digital platforms for reciprocity
- The role of anonymity in gift exchange
- Lessons for feminist HCI and research through design
- Layers of care (implicit, explicit, overt, and covert) embedded in an exchanged gift

Plan to attract a reasonable number of attendees

Ahead of the conference, we will combine targeted invitations to the communities listed above, together with an open call to register for the exchange, circulated through relevant mailing lists. For the conference programme and in the lead-up to the conference we would ensure that invitations to attend the meet-up are circulated within the community and would give assurances that all delegates would be welcome to attend the meet-up.

Requirements for the venue

We would like to request a space that can accommodate an estimated 80+ participants in a fixed layout that simultaneously supports exhibition display and group discussions. The room should be arranged with round tables throughout, each seating 6-8 people, serving a dual purpose: table surfaces will showcase participants' artifacts during the exhibition phase, and will then accommodate seated participants for small group conversations during the discussion phase. If possible, additional shelving units around the room perimeter would be beneficial for displaying more artifacts. The layout should provide sufficient space between tables to allow comfortable circulation and accessible pathways as attendees move through the room viewing the exhibited pieces on each table. A large display screen or projector will be required for showcasing the submitted images and videos of the making processes and our guided discussion prompts.